



A MIGHTY CAST: (From left) Winterbottom, Khan, Jolie, Futterman and Punjabi at Cannes

Triumph of Spirit

Winterbottom marries his docu-drama style to Jolie's exalted status and the result is electric. The ovation after the screening of *A Mighty Heart* proved that art can translate into commerce.

■ **By Moez Singh**

At the World Premiere in Cannes for *A Mighty Heart*, I huddled closely with Kailash and Arti Surendranath, the Indian Line producers of the movie, and we were jubilant. Michael Winterbottom, the idiosyncratic director, has created a modern masterpiece that at its core is the harrowing saga of a very pregnant woman on the verge of both motherhood and widowhood, played by Angelina Jolie to a perfect pitch. But the movie is also a sign of our times, as it strings together the calamitous

events that lead to the gruesome beheading of *Wall Street Journal* reporter Daniel Pearl (Dan Futterman), as he, armed with a foolish bravado, chases a story about foiled shoe bomber Richard Reid.

Set in Karachi, the film recounts the agonising and restless search for Pearl's whereabouts and the identities of his kidnappers, all of it spearheaded by Mariane Pearl (Jolie), and ably supported by a *Wall Street Journal* colleague Asra Nomani (Archie Punjabi); Captain, a local cop; (Irrfan Khan, in his third effortlessly sublime performance this year; American

diplomatic agent Randall Bennett (Will Patton) and *Wall Street Journal* boss (Denis O'Hare), amongst others.

Winterbottom, who has previously shunned big Hollywood studios, marries his independent docudrama-filming style (*In this World* and *Road to Guantanamo*) to Jolie's exalted Hollywood status, and the result is electric. Though the film is about the stomach-churning frustration brought on by false leads and unrewarding investigations that were often submerged under a deluge of media attention, because Pearl was Jewish and his kidnappers Islamic fundamentalists, it is also an



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